these undoubtedly took place in response to a variety of social, economic, political, and perhaps environmental factors (see Chapters 2 and 3). But as is the case with all historical processes, in the end the surviving evidence allows for the perception of only *some* of these factors.[30] Again, Burbank and Cooper have provided perhaps the most succinct description of the accidental convergence of circumstances that eventually coalesce as imperialism:

> In conditions of wide access to resources and simple technology, small advantages – larger family size, better access to irrigation or trade routes, good luck, ambitious and skillful rulers – can lead to domination of one group over another, setting in motion the creation of tribal dynasties and kingships.[31]

I have found such an apprehension of the Shansabanis' transformation to be invaluable for making fuller sense of many, previously opaque or misunderstood aspects of their trajectories, both within Afghanistan and beyond.

It is also worth noting that, unlike other nomadic/transhumant groups who attained transregional politico-economic power – most relevant would be the contemporaneous Sajluqs (cf. esp. Chapters 1 and 3) – the Shansabanis' shift from textually unrecorded nomadism and/or transhumance to the elite status celebrated in panegyrics, and ultimate imperial demise, are all documentable within approximately eighty to ninety years. Their nomadic/transhumant beginnings, then, would not have been a distant memory evoked in the nostalgia of elders; some form of these lifeways was conceivably still within the lived experience of the scions of the three principal Shansabani lineages at Firuzkuh, Bamiyan, and eventually Ghazna (Chapters 3–5). Thus, the Shansabanis' pre- and early imperial history – the focus of Volume I – is directly relevant to our investigation of their transformation into transregional builders of empire in Volume II.

Bennet Bronson's well-known and tantalizingly titled essay, "The Role of Barbarians in the Fall of States" (1988), is equally useful in examining the reverse, state-*building* process. Defining "barbarians" essentially as members of "a political unit … that is not itself a state," the author summarized thus their situation:

> If rich barbarians successfully resist both their state-organized and unorganized but poorer neighbors, it is probably because they have set up a state themselves. Barbarians who remain barbarians are therefore poor.[32]

Following Bronson's inimitable directness, many of the Ghuri "barbarians" remained poor, while the Shansabanis obviously did not. All the more reason to be cognizant of a distinction, pertinent especially as of the mid-twelfth century: the historical inhabitants of the region of Ghur